MODULE 05

Style and grooming

The fastest wins in the program: a haircut that fits your face, a clean beard, and clothes that fit.

Reading time	Budget	First visible results	Prerequisite
About 30 minutes	$150–400 one-time	Immediately	Module 01

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE, YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

Identify your face shape and choose a haircut that works with it.

Talk to a barber so you walk out with what you actually wanted.

Shape and maintain a beard, or shave without irritation.

Build a 15-piece capsule wardrobe where everything fits and goes together.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS

CONSENSUS Backed by research and professional guidelines.

PRELIMINARY Promising results, limited studies. Might be worth it, no guarantees.

WARNING Ineffective, risky, or both. Don't do it.

MEDICAL ADVICE This belongs to a healthcare professional.

5.1 Why style matters more than people think

Haircut, grooming and clothes are the parts of your appearance that change **the same day** you decide to change them. And they affect how people read you: in one study, identical faces were judged as more competent when shown wearing clothes perceived as wealthier, even when viewers were told to ignore clothing. PRELIMINARY

Note: most of this module is practical styling advice built on widely used conventions, not lab research. Where something is a convention, we say so; where it's evidence-based, it's labeled.

5.2 Face shape and haircut

Find your face shape

Pull your hair back, take a straight-on photo, and compare three widths (forehead, cheekbones, jaw) and your face length. Most people are a mix; pick the closest.

Shape	How to recognize it	Usually works	Usually avoid
Oval	Length a bit more than width, jaw slightly narrower than forehead	Almost everything	Heavy fringes that hide your proportions
Round	Width ≈ length, soft jaw, full cheeks	Height on top, shorter sides (fade, taper), quiff	Rounded bowl cuts, volume on the sides
Square	Strong, angular jaw, forehead ≈ jaw width	Classic short cuts, crew cut, side part, textured crop	Very sharp geometric lines that over-emphasize width
Oblong / rectangle	Clearly longer than wide	Medium length, some fullness on the sides, fringe	Very tall pompadours, very tight sides
Heart / triangle	Wide forehead, narrow chin	Medium length on top, textured fringe, a beard to add jaw width	Lots of height and volume at the top
Diamond	Wide cheekbones, narrower forehead and jaw	Fringe or textured top, fuller sides	Very short sides that highlight cheekbone width

These are styling conventions. Your hair type (straight, wavy, curly, coily), density and hairline matter just as much. A good barber will factor them in.

How to talk to your barber

1. **Bring 2–3 photos** of the cut you want, ideally on someone with similar hair type. Front and side.
2. **Use numbers.** Sides: clipper guard number (#1 = 1/8", #2 = 1/4", #3 = 3/8", #4 = 1/2"). Top: length in inches.
3. **Know the words.** *Fade*: sides blend down to skin or near-skin. *Taper*: gradual shortening, more conservative. *Texture*: cutting into the top so it looks less flat. *Scissor cut*: no clippers on the sides.
4. **Ask** how to style it and what product to use. Watch what they do.
5. **Rebook** before you leave: every 3–4 weeks for short cuts, 6–8 for longer ones.

Products in 30 seconds

Product	Hold / shine	Best for
Clay	Strong / matte	Textured, natural-looking short to medium cuts
Paste	Medium / low shine	Most cuts; easy to restyle
Pomade	Medium–strong / shiny	Slick, classic styles
Sea salt spray	Light / matte	Volume and texture before blow drying
Cream	Light / natural	Curly or longer hair, taming frizz

Use less than you think: a fingertip amount, warmed between your palms, worked from back to front. A blow dryer on medium heat makes a bigger difference than any product.

5.3 Beard and shaving

Should you grow a beard?

Grow it for **4 to 6 weeks without trimming** (except the neckline) before deciding. Early stubble always looks patchier than the final result. A beard can add visual width and definition to a softer or narrower jaw.

The two lines that matter

Line	Where	Common mistake
Neckline	Imagine a curve from just behind each earlobe down to about 1–2 finger-widths above your Adam's apple. Shave everything below.	Too high: it creates a double chin effect and a "floating" beard.
Cheek line	Natural line from sideburn to mustache corner. Only clean up stray hairs above it.	Cutting it too low and too straight, which looks artificial.

Maintenance

- **Trim weekly** with a beard trimmer and guards. Keep the sides slightly shorter than the chin for a more defined jaw.
- **Wash it** 2–3 times a week with a gentle cleanser or beard wash, and **use a beard oil or balm** to prevent itch and flakes.
- **Patchy beard?** Options: keep it short (stubble at 3–5 mm hides patchiness), or go clean-shaven. Both look better than a long patchy beard.

> MINOXIDIL FOR BEARD GROWTH?
>
> Some men use topical minoxidil off-label to grow a fuller beard. A few small studies suggest it can help, but evidence is limited, results may not last if you stop, and side effects (skin irritation, in rare cases heart-related effects) exist. PRELIMINARY
>
> This is a drug, not a grooming product. Talk to a doctor before starting. MEDICAL ADVICE

Shaving without irritation

1. Shave after a shower or with a warm towel: softer hair, less tugging.
2. Use a shaving gel or cream, not soap.
3. Shave **with the grain** first. Only go across if needed, never hard against it if you get bumps.
4. Sharp, clean blade. Rinse often. Replace every 5–7 shaves.
5. Rinse with cool water, then a fragrance-free moisturizer.

Frequent bumps (ingrown hairs) despite good technique? Switch to a trimmer that leaves 0.5–1 mm. If it persists, see a dermatologist. MEDICAL ADVICE

5.4 The details people notice

Detail	What to do
Eyebrows	Only remove the hair between the brows and obvious strays. Don't reshape or thin them: overplucked brows look odd on men and may not grow back fully.
Nose and ear hair	Trim with a dedicated trimmer every 1–2 weeks. Don't pluck nose hairs.
Nails	Short and clean. Trim weekly and file any rough edges.
Body odor	Shower daily, antiperspirant at night on dry skin (it works better than in the morning), clean clothes.
Fragrance	2–3 sprays maximum on neck and chest. If people can smell you from across the room, it's too much.
Lips	A lip balm with SPF. Cracked lips are a surprisingly visible detail.
Glasses	Choose frames that contrast your face shape: angular frames for round faces, rounder frames for square faces. Try in person.

5.5 Clothes: fit beats everything

A $20 T-shirt that fits will look better than a $200 one that doesn't. Before buying anything, learn what fit looks like.

Item	Good fit
T-shirt	Shoulder seam sits on your shoulder bone. Sleeves end mid-bicep, hugging lightly. Hem hits around the middle of your fly. No fabric ballooning at the waist.
Shirt	Same shoulder rule. You can pinch about 1–2 inches of fabric at the chest. Cuffs end where your wrist meets your hand.

Item	Good fit
Jeans / chinos	Comfortable at the waist without a belt. Slim or straight leg, tapering slightly. Little to no fabric bunching at the ankle ("no break" or "slight break").
Jacket	Shoulders end where yours do. Sleeves show a bit of shirt cuff. You can button it without pulling.
Shoes	Clean. Always. People look at shoes more than you think.

A tailor is your secret weapon. Hemming pants or taking in a shirt usually costs $10–30 and makes cheap clothes look custom.

Color basics

Build around **neutrals** that all match each other: navy, gray, white, black, olive, beige/khaki, brown. Then add one or two colors you like. If every piece goes with every other piece, getting dressed takes 30 seconds.

The 15-piece capsule wardrobe

Category	Pieces	Budget range
Tops	3 plain T-shirts (white, navy, gray), 1 black or olive T-shirt, 2 button-up shirts (white or light blue oxford, one darker), 1 crewneck sweater or quarter-zip	$90–200
Bottoms	1 dark jeans, 1 chinos (beige or olive), 1 gray or black pants or joggers that look clean	$80–180
Outerwear	1 versatile jacket (bomber, overshirt or denim), 1 hoodie or zip in a neutral color	$60–150
Shoes	1 clean white leather or minimalist sneakers, 1 boot or darker shoe	$80–200

You don't need to buy everything at once. Start with what you'll wear most: a few T-shirts that fit, one good pair of pants, clean sneakers.

> **SHOPPING RULES**
>
> **Try before you buy**, or buy from places with free returns. Sizes vary between brands.
>
> **Check the fabric**: cotton, wool, linen and blends wear better than thin polyester.
>
> **Avoid** big logos, slogans, very distressed jeans and anything you'd only wear once.
>
> **Thrift and outlet stores** are excellent for basics once you know your sizes.

5.6 Your module 05 checklist

- ☐ I've identified my face shape and saved 2–3 reference photos.
- ☐ I've booked a haircut and know what to ask for.

- ☐ I've chosen a styling product and practiced with it.
- ☐ I've decided: beard (with neckline and cheek line), stubble, or clean-shaven.
- ☐ I've sorted my wardrobe: kept what fits, donated what doesn't.
- ☐ I've listed the 3 pieces I'll buy first, and my sizes.

Sources

1. Oh D, Shafir E, Todorov A. Economic status cues from clothes affect perceived competence from faces. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 2020; 4: 287–293.
2. American Academy of Dermatology. How to shave; razor bumps and ingrown hairs. aad.org.
3. Ingprasert S, Tanglertsampan C, Tangphianphan N, Reanmanee C. Efficacy and safety of minoxidil 3% lotion for beard enhancement: a randomized, double-masked, placebo-controlled study. *Journal of Dermatology*, 2016; 43(8): 968–969.

This module is for aesthetic and educational purposes only. It does not replace advice from a qualified healthcare professional.